elements of the government. Neutral and intellectual voices weigh in on the conflicts that are played out in the public domain.

This policy process is a world of ideas and rational thinking, and not merely an exercise in power play. The continuous debate in an environment of dispersed power is the *reason* why democracies work well. The continuous process of criticism and debate finds and solves mistakes.

In the best of times, most people are greatly influenced by voices around them. On most subjects, we do not have deep expertise, and tend to go with the mainstream.

Conversely, if novel proposals are not vigorously contested, there is the danger of oddball ideas taking root. This problem is particularly seen in authoritarian countries. When the establishment takes a certain position, and there is a great deal of sycophantic applause, the climate of opinion shifts. This is also why authoritarian governments work badly.

When we think about criticizing the government, it is important to see that government is not a monolithic creature. Government is made up of many individuals and agencies, all of which have different points of view.

Criticism of the stated position of an agency generally strengthens the hand of the reformers within the agency. An environment where all criticism is attacked or proscribed is a recipe for policy paralysis. The really important initiatives will never achieve traction without an extensive reshaping of the larger discourse, in which criticism of the status quo is of central importance.

In some ideal world, government is like a nice NGO. Everyone is imbued with a shared sense of what is good for the people, and all cooperate in harmoniously building a utopia. Conflicts melt away because everyone appeals to the common good. This is an idealized world of agitprop documentaries.

Public choice theory encourages us to see that everyone involved in government works for herself, and all policymaking is marred by conflicts. Conflict is the normal state, and we should not be uncomfortable about it. Differences between persons and agencies are normal and healthy, and should be played out in the public domain. Differences arise out of